FPT UNIVERSITY – HO CHI MINH CITY CAMPUS

SWD391 – Software Architecture and Design

RESEARCH REPORT

Orchestrating Collaborative MLOps: An Analysis of the SkeltyMLOps Reference Architecture

Paper under study:

C. Daoud, D. Azar, C. Urtado, S. Vauttier, "A reference architecture for an orchestrated collaborative MLOps: A ground-up design from literature combining human and LLM expertise," *Future Generation Computer Systems*, vol. 185, 108700, 2026.
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Abstract

This report analyses the paper by Daoud et al. [1], which proposes SkeltyMLOps, a modular reference software architecture for *orchestrated collaborative* Machine Learning Operations (MLOps). The paper follows a two-phase design. In Phase 1, a systematic literature review of 53 peer-reviewed papers extracts 16 actor names and 402 activity statements, which are consolidated by human experts assisted by a Large Language Model (LLM) into five MLOps dimensions (Plan, Data, Model, Software, Ops) and 38 activities. In Phase 2, five published MLOps architectures are scored against the resulting 44-element scope to expose recurring coordination gaps, and SkeltyMLOps is designed from the ground up, with an MLOps Process Orchestrator that executes versioned coordination contracts over tickets and events. Following the assignment criteria, we present the paper's introduction, research questions, literature review, hypotheses, methods, data sources and results, and we close with our own critical assessment. We also recompute the paper's coverage metrics from its raw scoring matrix and find them consistent.

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1 Short Introduction

1.1 The paper at a glance

Table 1: Bibliographic overview of the paper under study.

Title	A reference architecture for an orchestrated collaborative MLOps: A ground-up design from literature combining human and LLM expertise
Authors	Charbel Daoud, Danielle Azar, Christelle Urtado, Sylvain Vauttier
Affiliations	SyCoIA, IMT Mines Alès (France); Dept. of Computer Science & Mathematics, Lebanese American University (Lebanon)
Venue	*Future Generation Computer Systems* (Elsevier), vol. 185, article 108700, 2026 – special issue "MLOps"
Timeline	Received 31 March 2026; revised 1 July 2026; accepted 2 July 2026; online 11 July 2026
Access	Open access (CC BY 4.0); DOI 10.1016/j.future.2026.108700
Relation to prior work	Extended version of a workshop paper presented at MLOps@ECAI 2025 [2]
Research type	Systematic literature review + design-oriented research (reference architecture)
Replication package	Raw extraction data, prompts, LLM configurations, scripts and outputs on Zenodo [3]
Funding	Région Occitanie (PLANETS project); French National Research Agency (AdaptiveMLOps, ANR-24-IAS2-0004)

1.2 Background and motivation

ML-powered software degrades after deployment. Machine learning (ML) is increasingly embedded in software, and the value of ML-powered software depends not only on model accuracy but on the ability to ship, operate and evolve all of its artefacts – data, models and code – reliably over time. Once deployed, models face changing data distributions (*data drift*), shifting user behaviour and evolving operational constraints, so performance may degrade *without explicit failures*. Sculley et al. [4] showed that these dynamics accumulate *hidden technical debt*: maintenance costs and operational risks grow unless the software supports monitoring, reproducibility and disciplined change management. MLOps emerged by borrowing and adapting DevOps practices so that operationalisation covers AI models and data, not only code.

A persistent engineering and coordination gap. Despite the growing number of MLOps tools and platforms, practitioners still face a gap: MLOps solutions are often assembled from heterogeneous tools whose integration and governance are complex, costly and hard to adapt. The authors argue that such integration decisions are really *coordination* decisions: specialised actors (data, model, software and operations engineers) must agree on ownership boundaries and handoff protocols. Breakdowns typically occur at cross-actor boundaries, where responsibilities are ambiguous and dependencies between data, models and software are neither explicit nor managed. In addition, the field lacks a commonly adopted definition of MLOps: studies use different terminology for its actors and activities, which makes it hard to design an architecture on a solid conceptual basis.

The proposal: SkeltyMLOps. To address this gap, the paper proposes SkeltyMLOps, a *reference* software architecture – i.e., a reusable template of structures, elements and relationships

for building software in a given domain – for orchestrated collaborative MLOps. The architecture is not designed ad hoc: it is derived "from the ground up" from a systematic literature review whose extracted terms are clustered and normalised by human experts assisted by LLMs. Its distinguishing feature is that *orchestration and cross-actor coordination* are placed at the core of the architecture, through an MLOps Process Orchestrator (MPO) and explicit coordination contracts.

1.3 Research objective and contributions

The paper's stated objective is to fill the absence of "an accepted, accessible, and modular reference architecture for MLOps" by designing one that promotes collaboration among the diverse actors involved. The authors list four contributions:

C1. a structured characterisation of MLOps from the literature, consolidating scattered terminology into a clear set of *actors*, *activities* and *dimensions*;

C2. a *consolidation process* that combines human and LLM expertise to normalise and cluster the extracted actors and activities;

C3. SkeltyMLOps, a modular reference architecture for orchestrated MLOps, built around tickets, handoffs and coordination contracts;

C4. a comparative *coverage analysis* against existing MLOps architectures, which the authors present as assessing how far the proposed architecture captures the identified activities and key collaboration concerns (see the clarification in Section 5 and point W1 in Section 8).

According to the abstract, the originality of the work is twofold: (1) the careful knowledge-gathering process that grounds the architecture, and (2) the central role given to orchestration and coordination.

1.4 Organisation of this report

Table 2 maps the assignment criteria to the sections of this report.

Table 2: Mapping between the assignment criteria and this report.

Criterion	What is covered	Section
Short Intro	Paper metadata, context, objective, contributions	1
Research Question	RQ1–RQ4, rationale, RQ-to-method-to-result mapping	2
Literature Review	DevOps→MLOps background, prior secondary studies, prior architectures, research gap	3
Hypothesis	Why no formal hypothesis; implicit hypotheses and design propositions	4
Methods	Two-phase design; Methods A–D; threats to validity	5
Data Source	Literature corpus, extracted data, LLM experiment data, baseline architectures	6
Result of the paper	Results for RQ1–RQ4, gap analysis, limitations and future work	7
(Additional)	Our critical assessment and verification	8

2 Research Questions

The study is organised in two phases, and four research questions (RQs) guide it. Phase 1 (*Literature Analysis Review*) answers RQ1–RQ3; Phase 2 (*Orchestration and Collaboration*) answers RQ4 using the results of Phase 1 as its foundation.

Research questions of the paper

Phase 1 – Literature Analysis Review

- **RQ1:** Who are the main actors involved in MLOps?
- **RQ2:** What are the dimensions of MLOps?
- **RQ3:** What are the activities that constitute MLOps processes?

Phase 2 – Orchestration and Collaboration

- **RQ4:** How can a modular MLOps reference architecture be designed to integrate the activities identified in RQ3 and to facilitate collaboration among the actors identified in RQ1?

2.1 Rationale of each question

RQ1 – Actors.
A collaboration-centred architecture must first know *who* collaborates. The literature names the same responsibilities differently (e.g., the model-building actor is called *Data Scientist* in some papers and *ML Engineer/Developer* in others), so the actors must be identified and consolidated before responsibilities can be assigned to architectural modules.

RQ2 – Dimensions.
A *dimension* is "a distinct functional area that groups related actors and responsibilities". DevOps has only two (Dev and Ops), which does not reflect data- and model-centric work. The dimensions give the architecture its top-level decomposition.

RQ3 – Activities.
Activities define *what* an MLOps process must support. The consolidated list is also reused as the scope for the coverage analysis in Phase 2.

RQ4 – Architecture.
This is a design question: how to turn the evidence of RQ1–RQ3 into a modular architecture in which activities are integrated and cross-actor collaboration is explicit.

2.2 From questions to answers

The questions form a progressive chain: *who* is involved (RQ1) → *how* they group into functional areas (RQ2) → *what* they do (RQ3) → *how* an architecture should integrate all of this and coordinate them (RQ4). Table 3 links each RQ to the method used and the main answer (details in Sections 5 and 7).

Table 3: Research questions, methods, paper sections and key answers.

RQ	Method(s)	Paper §	Key answer
RQ1	A (SLR, manual extraction) + B (LLM-assisted clustering)	§3, §4.1	16 extracted actor names consolidated into 5 clusters, each with a leading actor: Product Owner, Data Engineer, Model Engineer, Software Engineer, Operations Engineer.
RQ2	B	§4.1, §4.5	5 dimensions – Plan, Data, Model, Software, Ops – forming a "revisited MLOps loop" that splits the Dev side of DevOps into Data, Model and Software.
RQ3	A + B (5-step consolidation)	§4.2–4.4	402 activity statements consolidated into 38 activities: 17 shared with DevOps, 21 ML-specific.
RQ4	C (gap analysis) + D (ground-up design)	§5	SkeltyMLOps: 5 packages, 11 components (7 of which implement the 38 activities), and an MPO that executes coordination contracts over tickets and events.

3 Literature Review

3.1 From DevOps to MLOps

DevOps bridges software development and operations to shorten release cycles by formalising automation and fast feedback loops. It is commonly drawn as an infinite loop that links development activities (Plan, Code, Build, Test) with operational activities (Release, Deploy, Operate, Monitor), where production monitoring feeds back into requirements, planning and implementation. At a high level, this loop spans two dimensions: *Dev* and *Ops*.

In ML-powered software, the loop must absorb additional sources of change: after deployment, the data distribution may change, features may become outdated and model performance may degrade. Foundational work on ML technical debt [4] argues that these dynamics create hidden costs unless the software supports monitoring, reproducibility and disciplined change management. MLOps therefore extends DevOps by redefining development and operations around *code, data and models*, with mechanisms such as data and model versioning, experiment tracking, model registries, continuous evaluation, and retraining and redeployment when appropriate.

Although many tools and platform stacks exist, empirical and secondary studies report recurring architectural problems: the absence of unified architectural guidance, the complexity of integrating heterogeneous components, and the limited modularity of many commercial solutions. Studies of open-source practice further indicate that accessible and reusable reference architectures remain scarce.

3.2 Prior secondary studies

Several secondary studies have surveyed the MLOps field. Table 4 (reproduced from Table 1 of the paper) compares their scope along four concerns: actors, activities, coordination and architecture.

- **Kreuzberger et al.** [5] combine a literature review, a tool review and expert interviews to define MLOps principles, components and actors, and propose an overview architecture.
- **Najafabadi et al.** [6] map MLOps architectures through a systematic mapping study and synthesise 35 architectural components.

Table 4: Scope of prior secondary studies (✓ = primary concern; ∘ = partial; – = not addressed). Adapted from Table 1 of [1].

Study	# sources	Type	Actors	Activities	Coord.	Arch.
Kreuzberger et al. (2023) [5]	27	Mixed method	✓	✓	∘	✓
Najafabadi et al. (2024) [6]	43	Systematic mapping	–	–	–	✓
Eken et al. (2025) [7]	198	Multivocal review	✓	✓	∘	–
Woźniak et al. (2025) [8]	41	SLR	–	✓	–	✓
Daoud et al. (2026) (this paper)	53	SLR	✓	✓	✓	✓

- **Eken et al.** [7] conduct a multivocal review (including grey literature) covering practices, actors, activities, challenges and open issues.
- **Woźniak et al.** [8] review MLOps components, tools and process steps.

Although some of these studies report actors or activities, *none performs a systematic extraction and consolidation* that normalises the heterogeneous terminology into a unified characterisation linking actors to their activities. Moreover, coordination across actors – ownership boundaries, handoff specifications and governance mechanisms – is not treated as a primary concern in any of them.

3.3 Existing MLOps architectures

The paper positions its architecture against representative MLOps architectures that cover four complementary perspectives:

- *specialised operational architectures*, e.g., Rodrigues et al. [10] for near real-time distributed stream learning;
- *tool-oriented, open-source blueprints*, e.g., Burgueño-Romero et al. [11];
- *industry-driven reference architectures*, e.g., Kumara et al. [12], derived from industrial requirements and pipeline patterns;
- *survey-based overviews*, e.g., Najafabadi et al. [6] and Kreuzberger et al. [5].

These works clarify *what* MLOps software generally contains and which stages are commonly distinguished. However, they give limited guidance on *how* the actors coordinate their work across ownership boundaries, approvals, handoffs and runtime feedback loops.

3.4 Research gap

Research gap identified by the paper

G1. Fragmented terminology – there is no universally adopted definition of MLOps; actor and activity names vary across studies.

G2. Missing actor–activity mapping – no study jointly extracts and consolidates actors *and* activities from the literature.

G3. Implicit coordination – handoffs, ownership and governance are treated as by-products of tools or processes rather than as primary architectural concerns.

G4. Scarce reference architectures – accessible, modular and reusable reference architectures for MLOps are still missing.

G1 and G2 motivate RQ1–RQ3; G3 and G4 motivate RQ4.

4 Hypothesis

4.1 Why the paper has no formal hypothesis

The study does not follow a quantitative hypothesis-testing design. Instead of causal hypotheses (e.g., "H1: X positively affects Y"), it is organised around four research questions that guide an *exploratory, literature-grounded* investigation (RQ1–RQ3) and a *design-oriented* contribution (RQ4). This is consistent with its goal: characterising a domain and constructing an artefact (a reference architecture), rather than testing a relationship between variables.

Nevertheless, several hypothesis-like claims can be identified. Two are tested empirically in the LLM sub-study (Methods B), and two are propositions that the paper argues for without a statistical test.

4.2 Implicit hypotheses tested in the LLM sub-study

H1 – LLM configurations differ. *Different LLM configurations (provider, temperature and reasoning mode) yield measurably different levels of coverage, validity and stability when clustering and labelling MLOps actors.* The hypothesis is examined by running 13 configurations from OpenAI, Anthropic, Google and DeepSeek ten times each on the same clustering task and comparing four indicators (coverage, invalid items, duplicate assignments, and mean/standard deviation of the number of dimensions). The results support it: coverage ranges from 98.75% to 100%, mean duplicate assignments from 0 to 4 per run, and the standard deviation of the number of dimensions from 0.00 to 2.96. Gemini 2.5 Flash at temperature 0 is the only configuration that combines full coverage, zero invalid items, zero duplicates and a perfectly stable dimension count, and is therefore selected as the "champion".

H2 – Retrieval helps. *Adding Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) – giving the model the full PDF papers – improves consolidation quality for the champion configuration.* Tested by comparing RAG and no-RAG settings under the same prompt and parameters. The hypothesis is *not supported*: both reach 100% coverage, but the RAG configuration introduces an invalid actor ("ML Architect") that is not in the extracted list. The no-RAG configuration is retained.

4.3 Propositions argued without statistical testing

P1 – MLOps extends a DevOps backbone (descriptive). *MLOps builds on a software-delivery backbone inherited from DevOps while adding explicit activities for evolving data and model artefacts.* Supported descriptively by the consolidated activity list: 17 of the 38 activities also appear in DevOps, and several of the most frequently reported activities (e.g., Preprocess Data, Train Model, Evaluate & Test Model) are ML-specific.

P2 – Orchestration-centred design is reusable guidance (design proposition for RQ4). In its conclusion the paper claims that "an actor-aligned, orchestration-centered decomposition can serve as reusable architectural guidance for collaborative MLOps settings while remaining independent of a specific tool stack." This proposition is supported by (i) the traceable derivation of the architecture from the Phase 1 evidence, (ii) the gap analysis of five existing architectures and (iii) an illustrative data-drift scenario. It is *not* empirically tested: SkeltyMLOps has not been instantiated in a production setting, and it is not itself scored in the coverage analysis.

Table 5: Summary of implicit hypotheses and propositions.

ID	Statement	How examined	Status
H1	LLM configurations differ in coverage, validity and stability	13 configurations × 10 runs, 4 indicators	Supported → Gemini 2.5 Flash, $T = 0$
H2	RAG improves consolidation quality	RAG vs. no-RAG on the champion	Not supported → no-RAG kept
P1	MLOps = DevOps backbone + ML-specific activities	DevOps-overlap flag on the 38 activities	Supported descriptively (17/38 shared)
P2	Actor-aligned, orchestration-centred design is reusable guidance	Derivation, gap analysis, illustrative scenario	Argued and illustrated, not empirically tested

5 Methods Used in the Paper

5.1 Overall research design

The paper uses a *two-phase, mixed-method* design in which the output of Phase 1 becomes the input of Phase 2 (Figure 1). Phase 1 is a qualitative, evidence-based synthesis of the literature; Phase 2 is constructive (design-oriented). The chain is sequential and traceable: *literature → extracted evidence → consolidated scope (44 elements) → gap analysis of existing architectures → ground-up architecture design.*

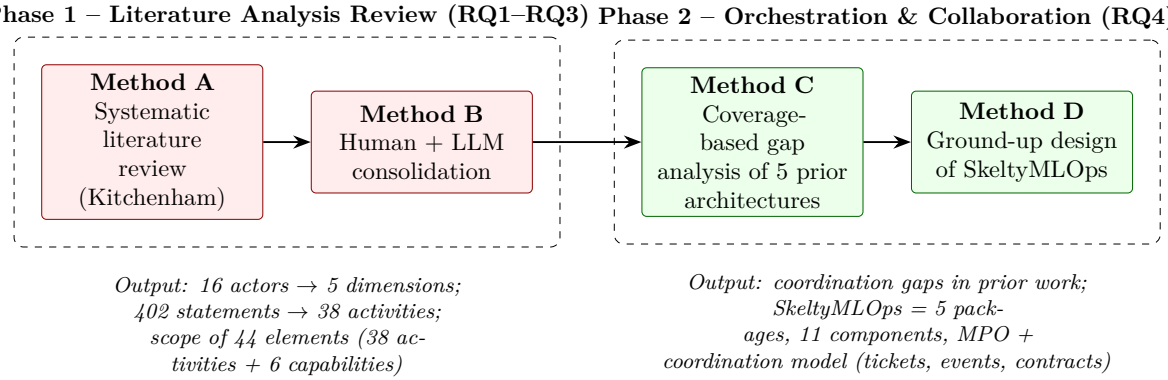


Figure 1: Two-phase research design (adapted from Fig. 2 of [1]; the gap-analysis step of Phase 2, described in §5.2–5.4 of the paper, is made explicit here).

Note on the order of Phase 2

In the paper, the comparison of existing architectures (§5.2–5.4) comes *before* the design of SkeltyMLOps (§5.5–5.9). The comparison therefore works as a *gap analysis that motivates the design*, not as a post-hoc benchmark of SkeltyMLOps against other architectures.

5.2 Phase 1 – Method A: Systematic literature review

The SLR follows Kitchenham's guidelines for systematic reviews in software engineering [9].

A1. Choice of data source. Google Scholar is used as a *meta-indexer*: a single query covers IEEE, ACM, Springer, Elsevier, MDPI and other publishers without adapting the query to each database.

A2. Search string. Terms are derived from RQ1–RQ3 (MLOps, actors, activities, processes, architecture) and refined with synonyms. The `allintitle:` operator targets papers that explicitly position themselves in the MLOps space (precision over recall); its limitations are compensated by screening and snowballing. The exact string is given in Section 6.

A3. Calibration. Two authors independently screen the same 10 pilot papers and resolve disagreements in a consensus meeting to finalise the interpretation of the criteria and coding rules.

A4. Screening with inclusion/exclusion criteria. A paper is *included* if it explicitly reports at least one extractable artefact: (i) a set of MLOps actors, (ii) a process depiction (e.g., a process figure), or (iii) an explicit enumeration of MLOps activities. It is *excluded* if it is non-English, has no accessible full text, is not peer-reviewed, or is only available through inaccessible subscriptions.

A5. Snowballing. Backward (cited) and forward (citing) snowballing mitigates the title-based query; new papers are filtered with the same criteria.

A6. Manual extraction. For each paper, the authors record bibliographic metadata, the actors mentioned (RQ1) and the activities reported in text or process figures (RQ3). A content-analysis approach with predefined categories is used, manually and independently by two authors; disagreements are resolved by consensus.

A7. Inter-rater agreement. Pre-consensus agreement is measured with Cohen's κ on a binary (present/absent) matrix: after synonym normalisation, the unique items across all papers form a reference list (38 actor names and 58 activity types), and each rater's extraction is coded per (paper, item) pair. Results: $\kappa = 0.808$ for actors and $\kappa = 0.780$ for activities, i.e., "substantial agreement" on the Landis–Koch scale [13].

5.3 Phase 1 – Method B: Human and LLM consolidation

Why a consolidation step is needed. The raw extraction is highly heterogeneous: actor names vary in naming and granularity (near-synonyms, overloaded names), some papers separate model-centric from software-centric actors, business actors are rarely visible (explicit in only 7 of the 38 papers contributing to RQ1), and the 402 activity statements range from fine-grained implementation steps to coarse process stages. Consolidating this by hand across papers would be slow and hard to reproduce, since different researchers may produce different groupings.

Principles for using LLMs.

- LLMs are *not* used for extraction, which is fully manual (Method A). They are used only to (i) cluster artefacts with similar meaning despite lexical variation and (ii) propose names for clusters.
- The LLM is an *analysis aid, not a decision maker*: all outputs are provisional and are revised or rejected by human experts (unsupported groupings, misleading names, overly general categories) through negotiated agreement.
- Every override is recorded in a *Human Modification Log* (modification type, proposed item, final item, justification), published in the replication package.
- All prompts share one structure: objective, artefact under analysis, constraints and output schema.

B1 – Controlled experiment to select the LLM configuration. Thirteen configurations from four providers are compared (Table 6). Temperatures 0 and 0.7 are used where available; temperature 1 is also used for Claude Sonnet 4.6 and Gemini 2.5 Flash to activate their reasoning mode; o3, o4-mini and DeepSeek Reasoner only allow their default temperature.

Table 6: The 13 LLM configurations compared (from Table 3 of [1]).

Provider	Model	Mode	Temperature(s)
Anthropic	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Chat / Reasoning	0, 0.7 / 1
DeepSeek	DeepSeek Chat	Chat	0, 0.7
DeepSeek	DeepSeek Reasoner	Reasoning	Default
Google	Gemini 2.5 Flash	Chat / Reasoning	0, 0.7 / 1
OpenAI	GPT-4o	Chat	0, 0.7
OpenAI	o3	Reasoning	Default
OpenAI	o4-mini	Reasoning	Default

Each configuration receives the same task (propose dimensions from the 16 actors, assign actors to dimensions, propose a leading actor per dimension) and is run 10 times. The indicators are:

- **Coverage (%)** – share of the extracted actors that appear in the output;
- **Invalid items per run** – mean number of items outside the extracted actor list;
- **Duplicate assignments per run** – mean number of actors assigned to more than one dimension;
- **Mean and standard deviation of the number of dimensions** – structural stability across runs;

plus compliance with the required output schema. Since almost all configurations reach full coverage, the selection is driven by correctness and stability: zero duplicates, low variability of the dimension count and consistent schema output.

B2 – RAG vs. no-RAG. For the champion, a RAG setting (extracted artefacts *and* full PDF papers) is compared with a no-RAG setting (prompt and extracted artefacts only), with identical prompt and parameters. This isolates the effect of external grounding.

B3 – Five-step consolidation of activities.

(1) **Assignment to validated dimensions** – the champion LLM classifies each of the 402 statements into one of the validated dimensions; humans correct misplaced assignments.

(2) **Dimension-specific clustering** – activities are clustered *within* each dimension to avoid merging activities that look similar but belong to different operational contexts.

(3) **Redundancy reduction and normalisation** – a dedicated prompt groups similar activities, avoids merging distinct tasks and produces concise, stable labels.

(4) **Expert review and final merging** – humans remove residual overlap, refine labels and check that each activity fits the responsibility boundaries of its dimension.

(5) **Final consolidation with metadata** – each activity receives a short description, a flag indicating whether it also appears in DevOps (assessed by human experts) and its frequency in the corpus.

5.4 Phase 2 – Method C: Coverage-based gap analysis of existing architectures

Baselines. Five published architectures are chosen to represent distinct contributions: an architecture for near real-time stream learning operations (Rodrigues et al. [10]), an open-source architecture blueprint (Burgueño-Romero et al. [11]), an industry-driven reference architecture (Kumara et al. [12]), an architecture synthesised from a mapping study (Najafabadi et al. [6]) and a survey-based overview architecture (Kreuzberger et al. [5]).

Scope of 44 elements. Each baseline is scored against the **38 consolidated activities** of Phase 1 plus **six cross-cutting capabilities**: (i) explicit actor-to-responsibility mapping, (ii) cross-actor handoff specification, (iii) traceability across data, model, code and operational artefacts, (iv) governance gates, (v) feedback loops (monitor → decision → action) and (vi) software versioning.

Scoring rubric. Each (baseline, element) pair receives a score $s \in \{0, 1, 2\}$:

- **Absent (0)** – the element is neither described nor supported, and cannot reasonably be grounded in the text or figures without speculation;
- **Partial (1)** – the element is mentioned or implied, but no concrete mechanism is specified (named module, process activity or actor ownership);
- **Explicit (2)** – the element is supported by an identifiable architectural element and/or a clearly described process activity with stated responsibilities and exchanged artefacts.

Procedure. Two authors score all baselines independently by mapping components in the architecture figures to elements, confirming scope and responsibilities in the descriptions, and running targeted keyword searches (*registry, versioning, CI/CD, monitoring, drift, pipeline, feature store, staging*). A rationale (section or figure reference plus justification) is recorded for every partial or explicit score. Pre-consensus agreement is measured with a quadratically weighted Cohen's kappa, $\kappa_w = 0.743$ (substantial), after which disagreements are resolved in a consensus meeting.

Metrics. With s_i the score of element i and $N = 44$:

$$\text{Total coverage} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{N} s_i}{2N}, \quad \text{Binary coverage} = \frac{|\{i : s_i \geq 1\}|}{N}, \quad \text{Strong coverage} = \frac{|\{i : s_i = 2\}|}{N}.$$

Binary coverage measures *breadth* (whether an element is present at all) and strong coverage measures *depth* (whether it is explicit).

Important clarification

The authors state that this assessment "is not interpreted as a quality ranking but rather as a structured comparison of explicitness with respect to a fixed scope derived from the literature." Only the five baselines are scored: Tables 7 and 8 of the paper contain *no column or row for SkeltyMLOps*.

5.5 Phase 2 – Method D: Ground-up architecture design

A reference architecture is a reusable blueprint that captures essential design principles, structural decomposition and interface-level guidance for a domain, allowing several concrete instantiations. SkeltyMLOps is derived from the Phase 1 results through explicit design rules:

D1. Dimension → package. Each of the five dimensions becomes a core package (Plan, Data, Model, Soft, Ops) that encapsulates one responsibility space.

D2. Activities → components. Groups of activities are assigned to components that implement them; every one of the 38 activities is mapped to exactly one component (Table 17).

D3. Separation of concerns. Components that *produce and evolve artefacts* (data, features, models, code, deployments), each with its own storage and versioning component, are separated from an *orchestration core* (MPO + Project Management).

D4. Coordination model. Coordination is designed explicitly through three concepts: *tickets* (ownership and progress), *events* (state changes such as a detected drift) and *coordination contracts* (how a ticket type progresses: inputs, outputs, approvals, escalation rules). The MPO executes the contracts.

D5. Illustration. The design is demonstrated with an illustrative data-drift scenario (sequence diagram) and a conditional gate expressed as pseudo-code, and its compatibility with non-functional concerns (scalability, fault recovery, interoperability, governance, security) is discussed.

This is constructive, design-science style research: the artefact is justified by traceability to evidence and by illustration, not by an empirical evaluation.

5.6 Threats to validity reported by the authors

5.7 Summary of methods

6 Data Sources

The study relies on four complementary data sources, each tied to a stage of the research.

Table 7: Threats to validity and mitigations (from §3.8 and §5.11 of [1]).

Phase	Threat	Risk	Mitigation
1	Internal	LLMs may produce unsupported merges, unstable names or inconsistent structures	Dual manual extraction, structured prompts, repeated runs, multi-provider comparison, human verification, RAG vs. no-RAG test
1	External	Corpus limited to peer-reviewed papers found via Google Scholar `allintitle:`; industrial practice under-represented	Snowballing; results framed as literature-grounded, not exhaustive
1	Reliability	Commercial LLM outputs change with versions and providers	Repeated runs, reported variability, full replication package
1	Conclusion	Descriptive indicators on a fixed task do not prove a unique valid consolidation	Claims restricted to the corpus, protocol and criteria used
2	Construct	Concerns absent from the literature (regulatory compliance, fairness, edge/federated deployment) are out of scope; coverage measures explicitness, not industrial completeness	Ongoing implementation orchestrating state-of-the-art tools (MLflow, DVC)
2	External	Architecture not instantiated or validated in production; stream and federated learning not assessed	Tool-agnostic design; implementation started with genericity in mind

Table 8: Overview of the four methods.

Method	Type	Input	Output	RQ
A	Qualitative (SLR, content analysis)	Google Scholar search results	53 papers; 16 actor names; 402 activity statements	1, 3
B	Mixed (controlled LLM experiment + human review)	Raw actors and activities	Champion LLM; 5 dimensions; 38 activities	1, 2, 3
C	Structured comparison (rubric scoring)	5 published architectures; 44-element scope	Coverage matrix and metrics; coordination gaps	4
D	Constructive / design-oriented	Results of A, B, C	SkeltyMLOps (packages, components, coordination model)	4

6.1 Source 1 – Literature corpus

The search was run on Google Scholar in March 2025 with the following string:

```
allintitle:(MLOps OR "machine learning operations") AND (actor OR actors OR
pipeline OR pipelines OR architecture OR architectures OR architecting OR activity
OR activities OR workflow OR workflows OR process OR processes)
```

Table 9: Construction of the corpus.

Step	Papers
Initial Google Scholar search (March 2025)	51
After inclusion/exclusion criteria	35
Added by backward and forward snowballing	+18
Final corpus	**53**
contributing to RQ1 (actors)	38
contributing to RQ3 (activities)	45
contributing to both	30

All PDFs were retrieved manually from publisher sites and each paper was checked to be peer-reviewed. The publisher distribution of the corpus – IEEE (36%), Springer (9%), Elsevier (8%), MDPI (8%) and ACM (6%), among others – shows that the meta-indexer approach covers the main venues.

6.2 Source 2 – Manually extracted data

Two authors independently extracted actor names and activity statements from the 53 papers ($\kappa = 0.808$ for actors, $\kappa = 0.780$ for activities). The raw extraction contains **16 actor names** (Table 10) and **402 activity statements**; the full activity list is available only in the replication package.

Table 10: The 16 manually extracted actor names and the number of papers citing each (from Table 2 of [1]).

Actor	Papers	Actor	Papers
Data Scientist	31	MLOps Engineer	6
Data Engineer	17	Domain Expert	5
ML Engineer/Developer	9	Software Developer	4
Software Engineer	8	Business Stakeholder	3
DevOps Engineer	8	Application Developer	3
Operations Engineer	7	IT Operations/Professional	3
Solution Architect	2	Manager	2
Data Steward	2	Scientist	2

6.3 Source 3 – LLM experimental data

A second, generated dataset consists of the outputs of 13 LLM configurations × 10 runs on the same actor-clustering task (130 runs), plus 10 runs of the RAG variant of the champion. This dataset is used to validate the *consolidation method*, not to answer the MLOps questions themselves.

6.4 Source 4 – Baseline architectures

The five published MLOps architectures [10, 11, 12, 6, 5] (their papers, figures and descriptions) are the data for Method C. They are used to identify recurring gaps in existing architectures with respect to the 44-element scope, not to benchmark SkeltyMLOps.

6.5 Replication package

The raw extraction data, prompts, evaluated LLM configurations and outputs, the scripts used to call the LLMs, the RAG implementation, the Human Modification Log and the JSON execution trace of the illustrative scenario are openly available on Zenodo [3] (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.21311713).

6.6 Limitations of the data sources

- **Title-only query.** `allintitle:` favours precision; relevant papers that do not use the terms in their titles depend on snowballing to be found.
- **Peer-reviewed only.** Grey literature and industrial reports are excluded, so actual industry practice may be under-represented (by contrast, Eken et al. [7] used a multivocal review of 198 sources).
- **Search-engine dependency.** Google Scholar results can change over time, which limits exact reproducibility of the search.
- **Moderate corpus size.** 53 papers, of which 38 inform RQ1 and 45 inform RQ3.

7 Results of the Paper

7.1 RQ1 and RQ2 – Actors and dimensions

Clustering the 16 extracted actors (Method B) and validating the result by human review yields five dimensions, each grouping an actor cluster and led by a *leading actor* (Table 11).

Table 11: Derived MLOps dimensions, actor clusters and leading actors (from Table 5 of [1]).

Dimension	Actor cluster	Leading actor
Plan	Business Stakeholder, Solution Architect, Manager, Domain Expert	Product Owner
Data Engineering (Data)	Data Scientist, Data Engineer, Data Steward	Data Engineer
Model Engineering (Model)	ML Engineer/Developer, Scientist	Model Engineer
Software Engineering (Software)	Software Engineer, Software Developer, Application Developer	Software Engineer
Operations (Ops)	DevOps Engineer, MLOps Engineer, Operations Engineer, IT Operations/Professional	Operations Engineer

The dimensions span the end-to-end engineering of ML-powered software. They serve two roles: they structure the reporting of activities (RQ3), and they inform the modular decomposition

of SkeltyMLOps (RQ4) by aligning architectural packages with responsibility boundaries. Beyond the clusters, the paper reports several observations about actors: heterogeneous and overloaded names, a boundary between model-centric and software-centric actors, few cross-cutting actors (e.g., Domain Expert), low visibility of business actors, and different granularities of responsibility across papers.

7.2 Selection of the LLM configuration

Table 12: Comparison of LLM configurations, 10 runs each (from Table 4 of [1]). The selected champion is highlighted.

Identifier	RAG	Temp.	Cov. (%)	Invalid	Dup.	Mean dim.	SD dim.
`claude-sonnet-4-6`	×	0	100	0	1	6	0.82
`claude-sonnet-4-6`	×	0.7	100	0	1	6	0.79
`claude-sonnet-4-6`	×	1	100	0	0	7	2.96
`deepseek-chat`	×	0	100	0	0	3	0.32
`deepseek-chat`	×	0.7	100	0	1	3	0.00
`deepseek-reasoner`	×	Default	100	0	0	5	0.57
`gemini-2.5-flash`	×	0	100	0	0	6	0.00
`gemini-2.5-flash`	×	0.7	100	0	4	6	1.17
`gemini-2.5-flash`	×	1	100	0	2	6	1.25
`gemini-2.5-flash`	✓	0	100	1	0	6	0.00
`gpt-4o`	×	0	100	0	1	5	1.29
`gpt-4o`	×	0.7	100	0	1	5	1.07
`o3`	×	Default	100	0	1	7	0.74
`o4-mini`	×	Default	98.75	0	0	6	0.71

All configurations reach full coverage except `o4-mini` (98.75%). Several configurations introduce duplicate assignments (e.g., GPT-4o, o3, Claude Sonnet at temperatures 0 and 0.7) or show high variability of the dimension count (e.g., DeepSeek Reasoner, GPT-4o, o3). DeepSeek Chat at temperature 0 has no duplicates but produces a coarser clustering (about 3 dimensions), which is too coarse for architectural decomposition. Higher temperatures make Gemini 2.5 Flash less stable. **Gemini 2.5 Flash at temperature 0 without RAG** is therefore selected: 100% coverage, 0 invalid items, 0 duplicates and a stable dimension count (SD = 0.00). The RAG variant adds the invalid actor "ML Architect" and is rejected.

7.3 RQ3 – The 38 consolidated activities

The five-step consolidation reduces the 402 activity statements to **38 activities** (Table 13): 7 in Plan, 8 in Data, 9 in Model, 5 in Software and 9 in Ops.

Table 13: The 38 consolidated MLOps activities, whether they also appear in DevOps, and the number of papers reporting them (from Table 6 of [1]).

ID	Activity	Brief description	DevOps?	Count
Plan – leading actor: Product Owner				
P1	Conceptualize Project	Define business goal, context, and scope.	✓	5
P2	Define Requirements	Elicit requirements and constraints.	✓	2
P3	Formulate ML Problem	Translate the business goal into an ML problem.	×	3

continued on next page

Table 13 (continued)

ID	Activity	Brief description	DevOps?	Count
P4	Analyze Data Sources	Identify required data and assess available sources.	×	3
P5	Design Architecture	Define system design, components, and technologies.	✓	3
P6	Plan Project	Plan work, milestones, and delivery approach.	✓	5
P7	Initialize Repositories	Set up version control and artifact repositories.	✓	3
Data – leading actor: Data Engineer				
D1	Collect Data	Acquire raw data from internal or external sources.	×	14
D2	Ingest Data	Load data into storage/pipeline (batch or streaming).	×	7
D3	Validate Data	Verify schema, integrity, and basic data quality.	×	7
D4	Preprocess Data	Clean and transform data for modeling.	×	28
D5	Engineer Features	Create and transform features for training/inference.	×	8
D6	Label Data	Create or refine labels/annotations.	×	2
D7	Analyze Data	Perform exploratory data analysis to assess issues.	×	10
D8	Manage Data	Version, catalog, and govern datasets and features.	×	3
Model – leading actor: Model Engineer				
M1	Run Experiments	Execute and track experimental runs and outcomes.	×	5
M2	Design Model	Select the model approach and key design choices.	×	10
M3	Develop Model	Implement the model in the chosen framework.	×	11
M4	Train Model	Fit the model on data; retrain as needed.	×	29
M5	Tune Model	Optimize hyperparameters and training settings.	×	3
M6	Validate Model	Check correctness and compliance against criteria.	×	11
M7	Evaluate & Test Model	Assess performance on test/holdout and analyses.	×	25
M8	Optimize Model	Improve efficiency/quality (e.g., compression).	×	3
M9	Register Model	Store model artifact and metadata in a registry.	×	13
Software – leading actor: Software Engineer				
S1	Develop Code	Implement ML and non-ML software components.	✓	8
S2	Build Components	Build/containerize components and produce artifacts.	✓	12
S3	Package Artifacts	Bundle components/models into deployable artifacts.	✓	10
S4	Test Solution	Run checks and tests before release.	✓	12
S5	Release Solution	Publish artifacts to target repositories/environments.	✓	4
Ops – leading actor: Operations Engineer				
O1	Configure CI/CD	Set up automated build, test, and release pipelines.	✓	9
O2	Manage Infrastructure	Provision and configure runtime infrastructure.	✓	3

continued on next page

Table 13 (continued)

ID	Activity	Brief description	DevOps?	Count
O3	Execute Pipelines	Run orchestrated workflows on schedule/trigger.	✓	7
O4	Deploy to Testing	Deploy to staging for validation.	✓	3
O5	Deploy to Production	Deploy validated release to production.	✓	27
O6	Serve Inference	Provide online/batch inference and log outputs.	×	11
O7	Monitor Performance	Track metrics, drift, and alerts in production.	✓	19
O8	Trigger Retraining	Start retraining based on signals or new data.	×	3
O9	Operate & Maintain	Handle incidents, feedback, and service upkeep.	✓	6

Frequency is concentrated. Four activities appear in at least 25 papers: *Train Model* (29), *Preprocess Data* (28), *Deploy to Production* (27) and *Evaluate & Test Model* (25). By contrast, twelve activities appear in at most three papers. The literature therefore repeatedly reports a small core focused on data preparation, model training and evaluation, and production deployment.

Overlap with DevOps. 17 of the 38 activities also appear in DevOps (repository setup, build, test, release, CI/CD configuration, deployment, monitoring and operations); the other 21 are ML-specific. The overlap is concentrated in the Plan (5/7), Software (5/5) and Ops (7/9) dimensions, while *none* of the Data and Model activities belong to DevOps. Among the shared activities, the most frequently reported are Deploy to Production (27) and Monitor Performance (19); among the ML-specific ones, Train Model (29), Preprocess Data (28) and Evaluate & Test Model (25). This supports proposition P1: MLOps keeps a DevOps delivery backbone and adds explicit activities for data and model artefacts.

Under-reported activities. Using "mentioned in ≤ 3 papers" as the definition of rarity, the rare activities include planning work (Define Requirements, Analyze Data Sources), infrastructure and pre-production steps (Manage Infrastructure, Deploy to Testing), model refinement (Tune Model, Optimize Model), data governance and labelling (Manage Data, Label Data) and closed-loop operation (*Trigger Retraining*). The authors interpret this as concerns that are under-reported or left implicit in published process descriptions, despite their role in the end-to-end evolution of ML-powered software.

7.4 The revisited MLOps loop

The actors, dimensions and activities are summarised in a *revisited MLOps loop* (Fig. 5 of the paper). Compared with the two-dimension DevOps loop, it keeps *Plan* and *Ops* and splits the engineering (Dev) segment into three dimensions: *Data*, *Model* and *Software*. Each dimension is annotated with its leading actor and its activities. Planning is led by the Product Owner, with contributions from the Data, Model, Software and Operations Engineers. The loop is a synthesis of the Phase 1 results rather than an additional derivation step.

7.5 Gap analysis of existing architectures (Method C)

Table 14 reports the coverage metrics of the five baselines.

Table 14: Coverage metrics of the five baselines against the 44-element scope (from Table 8 of [1]).

Architecture	Nature	Total	Binary	Strong
Kreuzberger et al. [5]	Survey-based overview architecture	89.8%	100%	80%
Kumara et al. [12]	Industry-driven reference architecture	78.4%	93%	64%
Najafabadi et al. [6]	Synthesised from a mapping study	60.2%	70%	50%
Burgueño-Romero et al. [11]	Open-source architecture blueprint	55.7%	73%	39%
Rodrigues et al. [10]	Near real-time stream learning operations	37.5%	48%	27%

- **Kreuzberger et al.** reach full breadth (100% binary), consistent with an overview architecture, but only 80% strong coverage: several elements remain conceptual rather than operationalised.
- **Rodrigues et al.** score lowest, consistent with a specialised architecture targeting stream learning rather than end-to-end MLOps.
- **Burgueño-Romero et al.** and **Najafabadi et al.** occupy the middle: they cover many technical components (especially Model and Ops) but are weaker on planning and on coordination mechanisms.
- **Kumara et al.** provide strong end-to-end conformance, consistent with an industry-driven reference architecture; their remaining gaps lie in planning and in the full specification of governance and release management.

To make the pattern visible per dimension, our group aggregated the raw scores of Table 7 of the paper (Table 15). Planning is the weakest dimension for every baseline except the overview of Kreuzberger et al., and for four of the five baselines the cross-cutting coordination capabilities score lower than the Software and Ops activities. Kumara et al. obtain the highest score on the cross-cutting capabilities.

Table 15: Coverage per dimension (sum of scores / maximum score). *Computed by our group* from Table 7 of [1].

Dimension	# elements	Rodrigues	Burgueño-R.	Kumara	Najafabadi	Kreuzberger
Plan	7	14%	21%	43%	21%	86%
Data	8	25%	31%	81%	88%	94%
Model	9	33%	61%	83%	50%	94%
Software	5	60%	60%	80%	90%	100%
Ops	9	61%	94%	94%	72%	94%
Cross-cutting capabilities	6	33%	58%	83%	42%	67%

Table 16: Scores of the six cross-cutting capabilities (– absent, ○ partial, ● explicit), from Table 7 of [1].

Capability	Rodrigues	Burgueño-R.	Kumara	Najafabadi	Kreuzberger
Explicit actor-to-responsibility mapping	–	○	●	–	○
Cross-actor handoff specification	●	●	●	●	●
Traceability across artifacts	○	○	●	○	○
Governance gates	–	–	○	–	○
Feedback loops	○	●	●	●	●
Software versioning	–	○	○	–	○

Main finding of the gap analysis

Many architectures support retraining, deployment and monitoring, but they often leave *ownership boundaries, handoff payloads, approval logic and release-level traceability* implicit. No baseline makes *governance gates* or *software versioning* explicit. In the authors' words, the literature describes *what* technical components and stages are involved in MLOps, but offers less explicit guidance on *how* collaboration is organised and enforced. This directly motivates treating coordination as a key architectural concern in SkeltyMLOps.

7.6 RQ4 – The SkeltyMLOps reference architecture

Package level. SkeltyMLOps is structured into five core packages – **Plan**, **Data**, **Model**, **Soft** and **Ops** – each corresponding to one dimension and encapsulating a coherent responsibility space. The packages are coordinated through a dedicated orchestration core.

Component level. Each package is refined into components that expose interfaces for coordination. Table 17 maps the 38 activities to the seven activity-implementing components.

Table 17: Mapping between SkeltyMLOps components and activities (from Table 9 of [1]; package column added from Fig. 6).

Component	Package	Implemented activities
Project Management	Plan	Conceptualize Project, Define Requirements, Formulate ML Problem, Analyze Data Sources, Design Architecture, Plan Project, Initialize Repositories
Data Acquisition	Data	Collect Data, Ingest Data
Data Processing & Feature Engineering	Data	Preprocess Data, Validate Data, Engineer Features, Label Data, Analyze Data, Manage Data
Model Development & Training	Model	Run Experiments, Design Model, Develop Model, Train Model, Tune Model, Validate Model, Evaluate & Test Model, Optimize Model, Register Model
API Development	Soft	Develop Code, Build Components, Package Artifacts, Test Solution, Release Solution
Deployment & Monitoring	Ops	Configure CI/CD, Manage Infrastructure, Deploy to Testing, Deploy to Production, Serve Inference, Monitor Performance, Operate & Maintain
MLOps Process Orchestrator (MPO)	Ops (core)	Execute Pipelines, Trigger Retraining

Besides these seven components, four *storage and versioning* components preserve artefacts and their history: Data Storage & Versioning and Feature Storage & Versioning (Data), Model Storage & Versioning (Model) and Code Storage & Versioning (Soft). Versioning is a key concern and should support multi-granularity artefact histories and controlled co-evolution of related artefacts. The Deployment & Monitoring component emits runtime events (degradation, drift indicators, anomalies) that may trigger contract-driven responses.

Core coordination model. Coordination between actors relies on three concepts:

- a **ticket** assigns ownership and tracks progress;
- an **event** is emitted by a component to report a state change (e.g., a ready dataset or a detected drift);

- a **coordination contract** defines how a type of ticket progresses: required inputs, expected outputs, approvals and escalation rules.

The **MLOps Process Orchestrator (MPO)** executes these contracts: for each ticket it creates an execution instance under a specific contract version, dispatches work, manages handoffs and records execution evidence. Contracts can contain automated tasks and *human gates*; a ticket cannot move forward until the required evidence and approvals are recorded. Each handoff is an explicit contract transition that specifies the *producer* actor, the *consumer* actor, the *triggering condition*, the *artefact exchanged* and the *metadata required for traceability*. The MPO works with the *Project Management* component, which creates and prioritises tickets, captures requirements and constraints, and assigns ownership. Because processes are described as versioned contracts (e.g., BPMN processes uploaded as input artefacts), projects can vary their processes without changing the architecture.

Illustrative ticket lifecycle (data drift). The paper walks through one ticket of a drift-response process previously designed by the Product Owner (Fig. 7 of the paper). Every message passes through the MPO:

Step 1. Drift detection – Deployment & Monitoring (Ops) detects data drift and emits a `DRIFT_DETECTED` event.

Step 2. Ticket creation – the MPO creates a ticket bound to the contract `drift-response-v1`.

Step 3. Plan approval – the ticket is routed to Plan (`WAITING_APPROVAL`); the Product Owner reviews the drift, evaluates the need to retrain, approves and sets priority.

Step 4. Dataset update – handoff to Data; the Data Engineer collects and labels data, validates quality and registers `dataset-v3`.

Step 5. Model retraining – handoff to Model; the Model Engineer retrains with `dataset-v3`, evaluates it and registers `model-v2.1` with its evaluation evidence.

Step 6. Code update – handoff to Soft; the Software Engineer updates the serving endpoint, runs tests and commits the changes.

Step 7. Deployment and closure – handoff back to Ops for deployment and health checks; the MPO validates the contract (5/5 gates passed) and closes the ticket with the full execution trace (JSON, in the replication package).

At each handoff the contract requires the relevant artefact and approval before the ticket advances: for example, the Data-to-Model transition cannot proceed until the dataset artefact and its approval are recorded.

Conditional gates. Contracts can route a ticket along different paths depending on runtime conditions. In the scenario, a retrained model may or may not change the input schema expected by the serving API; Step 6 is executed only if it does:

Algorithm 1 – Conditional gate in the drift-response contract (from [1])

GATE 4 – Conditional: API Impact
if `model.input_schema` ≠ `api.current_schema` **then**
    GATE 4a – Code Update
    actor: Software Engineer
else
    skip to **GATE 5**
end if

Non-functional concerns. SkeltyMLOps does not prescribe a technology stack, but the MPO design is compatible with patterns that address practical deployment concerns:

- **Scalability** – interactions are compatible with event-driven, message-broker architectures, where contract execution can scale horizontally if ticket state is stored externally;
- **Fault recovery** – persistent ticket states let a failed transition resume from the last recorded state;
- **Interoperability** – standard interfaces (ticket assignment, event consumption, artefact registration) and adapters allow each module to be implemented with different tools;
- **Governance and audit** – each contract states which actor is responsible for each transition, and the MPO records an append-only audit trail (acting actor, timestamp, artefact produced); combined with artefact versioning this forms a provenance chain from data source to deployed model;
- **Security** – tickets carry only artefact references, not data; data-level and network security are delegated to the domain tools connected through the adapters.

7.7 Limitations and future work reported by the authors

The authors acknowledge three residual gaps: (1) the architecture has *not been instantiated in a production setting*; (2) contract design is still *manual* rather than generated from organisational policies; and (3) interactions between *concurrent tickets* are not yet addressed. Planned future work includes: (i) a reusable palette of process templates that product owners can configure; (ii) support for continuous learning (incremental updates and rollback of evolving models); (iii) turning the orchestrator into a standalone application interoperating with actor-specific tools, with scalability and reliability validated in a production-like setting; (iv) quality assurance for ML-powered software, including model-fairness checks; and (v) integrating security concerns into the coordination layer.

8 Critical Assessment by Our Group

This section gives our own evaluation of the paper. It is separate from the results reported by the authors.

8.1 Strengths

S1. Rigorous and transparent SLR. The review follows Kitchenham's guidelines, calibrates the criteria on pilot papers, uses dual independent extraction and reports pre-consensus agreement ($\kappa = 0.808$ and 0.780).

S2. Principled, auditable use of LLMs. Instead of trusting a single model, the authors compare 13 configurations over repeated runs, keep humans as final decision makers, log every override and publish prompts and outputs. This design could be reused in other literature-synthesis studies.

S3. Traceability from evidence to architecture. Each package corresponds to a dimension and each activity to a component (Table 17), so design decisions can be traced back to the literature.

S4. Coordination as a first-class concern. Tickets, events, versioned contracts, governance gates and an append-only audit trail address the collaboration problems that the gap analysis shows are usually left implicit, without tying the design to a specific tool.

S5. Internally consistent numbers. Our group recomputed the three coverage metrics of all five baselines from the raw scores in Table 7 of the paper: all fifteen values match Table 8 after rounding.

8.2 Weaknesses and open questions

W1. Asymmetric evaluation. The contribution list and the conclusion describe the coverage analysis as assessing the *proposed* architecture, but Tables 7–8 score only the five baselines. SkeltyMLOps covers the 38 activities *by construction* (Table 17), and the scope is derived from the same literature the architecture is built from, so full activity coverage is nearly guaranteed. Scoring SkeltyMLOps with the same rubric by independent raters, at least on the six cross-cutting capabilities, would make the comparison more convincing.

W2. Tension on handoffs. Table 7 scores "cross-actor handoff specification" as *explicit* for all five baselines, while the text argues that handoff payloads are usually left implicit, and the introduction presents undefined handoff protocols as a core motivation. The paper does not reconcile the two. A plausible explanation is that the rubric credits data flows between components, whereas the narrative refers to actor-level payloads and approvals; a finer-grained criterion would strengthen the argument.

W3. Human adjustments not detailed in the text. The champion configuration produces on average 6 dimensions (SD = 0.00, Table 12), while the final validated structure has 5 (Table 11). The text does not say which dimension was merged or removed; this is presumably in the Human Modification Log, which we did not inspect. Likewise, the leading actors *Product Owner* and *Model Engineer* are not among the 16 extracted names: they are synthesised labels rather than observed roles.

W4. Debatable clustering of Data Scientist. The most cited actor (Data Scientist, 31 papers) is placed in the Data dimension, although the paper itself notes that several papers use "Data Scientist" for the model-building actor. Since packages follow ownership boundaries, this choice affects the responsibility split between the Data and Model packages.

W5. LLM selection based on one small task. The 13-configuration comparison is run only on the actor-clustering task (16 items). The champion is then used for the much larger activity consolidation (402 statements) without a separate comparison on that task.

W6. No empirical validation of the architecture. There is no instantiation, case study or practitioner evaluation; the data-drift walkthrough is illustrative. Concurrent tickets, contract authoring effort and the orchestration overhead of human gates remain open questions.

W7. Corpus and reproducibility limits. Title-only search, 53 peer-reviewed papers and a March 2025 cut-off may miss industrial practice. Exact reproduction of the LLM step also depends on specific commercial model versions that may change or be retired.

8.3 Relevance and suggested follow-up

For practitioners, the main lesson is to treat an ML pipeline orchestrator not only as a job scheduler but as a *workflow and governance engine*: who owns each step, which artefact must be handed over, who approves it, and how every transition is recorded. The authors report that an implementation orchestrating existing tools (such as MLflow and DVC) is ongoing. Follow-up studies could (i) score SkeltyMLOps with the same rubric and independent raters, (ii) validate the actor and activity lists through practitioner interviews or surveys, (iii) run an industrial case study measuring coordination effort and lead time, and (iv) extend the corpus with a multivocal review that includes grey literature.

9 Conclusion

Daoud et al. address a real gap in MLOps: many tools exist, but there is little architectural guidance on how the actors who build ML-powered software should coordinate. Phase 1 turns a heterogeneous literature into a consolidated vocabulary of five dimensions, five leading actors and 38 activities, using an SLR and a carefully controlled human–LLM consolidation process. Phase 2 shows that existing architectures describe *what* MLOps involves but leave *how* actors coordinate largely implicit, and proposes SkeltyMLOps, which puts orchestration and coordination contracts at the centre of the architecture. The methodological transparency of the study is its strongest point. Its main limitation is the evaluation: the architecture is justified by traceability and an illustrative scenario, not by empirical validation or by scoring it against the same benchmark as the baselines. Overall, SkeltyMLOps is a well-grounded reference point for collaborative MLOps, whose practical value still has to be demonstrated through implementation and industrial evaluation.

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